

BUT IS IT HONEST?

(a short story by Sharon Dexter)

Expressive Reading – Tubutubu Nailovolovo

“Honesty is the best policy.”

Sure, I’ve heard that before – a lot. Especially from Mom when she wants me to admit I’ve goofed. But I never *really* believed it, deep down, until this fall.

Jake and I were at the mall one Thursday last August. In the dollar store, I saw him reach for some tattoo stickers and put them casually into his back jeans pocket. He winked and grinned when he saw me staring at him as we left. I didn’t want to make a fuss about it at the time. After all, it was only 25 cents. Big deal.

I was surprised it still bothered me that night. “What do I do, Lord? It wasn’t even worth a buck. He’s a good friend, I don’t want to get him in trouble.”

On Saturday, my parents brought Jake and his younger brother with our family to the zoo. “My mom gave me money for the two of us,” Jake told my dad. He and Pete went up to the ticket window in front of me. The sign said, “Children under age eight free.”

“My brother won’t be eight until next month,” he said as he put the correct amount for his own ticket. I happen to know Pete turned *nine* last week. But he’s small for his age, so the lady let him through.

“Jake,” I protested after Dad got our family through the turnstile.

“Hey, who cares? Everybody does it, Sally,” Jake said, punching my shoulder.

I was uneasy but I forgot about it when dad took us to the concession stand for soda and a bag of popcorn. Then Jake and I made our way to my favourite exhibit – the monkey house. Jake got a kick out of tossing popcorn to a chimpanzee.

“Jake,” I said, nodding towards the “DO NOT FEED” sign.

“Hey, I’m not the only one – look!” Jake pointed to an old banana peel, some apple cores and a lot of popcorn that other people had thrown in. It was gross, but he kept on feeding the chimp until he saw a keeper nearby.

Several incidents like that took place in the weeks ahead. Jake couldn’t seem to be honest about anything. *Lord, what can I do?* I prayed. I like Jake, but what he’s doing just isn’t right.

Three weeks ago, what Jake did was the final straw with me. We were at the mall again, looking at CDs.

“I like this one,” he said, then Jake quickly looked around to see if anyone was watching.

“No,” I said, grabbing his arm.

“What’s got into you?” Jake demanded. “You’ve never tried to stop me before.

I realized then that I had let my friend down all this time. Here I’d been asking God what to do when I knew all along. “I’m sorry, Jake, but I don’t need a friend who’s dishonest.” I turned and walked away, leaving him standing there with his mouth wide open. It was the hardest thing I’ve ever done.

All the next week, I wanted to call him, but I forced myself to wait.

"Sally, did you and Jake have a fight?" Mom asked. "Why haven't you been pestering me about going somewhere with him lately?"

"I don't know, Mom," I told her. "I'm hoping we can work it out, but I can't really talk about it yet, okay?"

Mom gave me a wondering look but I was grateful she didn't ask any more questions.

Finally, last Friday night, the phone rang. "It's for you," Mom said. "It's Jake." Her smile looked hopeful.

I said a quick prayer in my head as I grabbed the phone. "Hi, Jake," I said. "Thanks for calling."
"Did you mean what you said?" Jake asked, a catch in his voice.

"Yeah, I had to say it. You know God is in charge of my life. I can't just pretend it doesn't matter to lie and steal. It really makes me feel bad to see you breaking God's rules."

Jake was silent a moment. "Maybe you could pray for me," he finally said.

"It's a deal," I answered, "So, you want to see a movie tomorrow."

I don't remember what we saw. We talked some more about dishonesty. We had fun together again. My good friend was back.

Last night I cut out an article from the newspaper and handed it to Jake when he came over. His eyes opened wide at the headline, "Teen Shoplifters Arrested." He scanned the story. Jake took a deep breath and blew it out slowly.

"Thanks for being straight with me, Sally. Being honest *is* better."

"Let's go play my new video game," I said, leading the way to the games room. "I *honestly* intend to beat you!"